

Akhil Bodahanapati

University of Pittsburgh, Computer Science, Expected December 2027

Perez Mayoral Trailblazer Scholarship

Describe your ultimate career or advocacy goals and how you envision making an impact in your community.

When people find out I grew up in Cupertino, they usually assume they know my story. Good schools, nice neighborhood, parents with tech jobs, a straight line to a computer science degree. I understand why. From the outside, that's what it looked like.

What they don't see is everything that happened inside our house. My family dealt with health problems that didn't go away and didn't wait for a good time. We moved more than once, and each move meant a new school, new people, and starting over. Money got tight in ways nobody around us would have guessed. That was its own kind of hard, because in a place like Cupertino, struggling is something you keep to yourself.

The thing I remember most from those years isn't one big moment. It's how much time went into just figuring things out. Who do you call? What does this letter mean? Which form is the right one, and what happens if you get it wrong? Every system we dealt with, whether it was medical, financial, or school, seemed built for people who already knew how it worked. If you didn't, you were expected to figure it out alone, usually while you were already stretched thin.

That's where my idea of advocacy comes from. I don't picture standing at a podium. I picture the person at the kitchen table at midnight, trying to understand a bill or a denial letter, who doesn't know they have options. Most people who get lost in these systems aren't failing because they don't care. They're failing because the information is buried, confusing, or written for someone else.

I'm studying computer science at the University of Pittsburgh and graduating in December 2027. I chose CS partly because it was the one thing in my life that felt fair. Code either works or it doesn't, and if you put in the effort, you can see exactly where you went wrong and fix it. When everything else felt unstable, that mattered to me. Over time, I've realized that the same skill can be used to make other people's lives feel a little more fair too.

My goal is to build software that helps people get through the systems that are supposed to serve them. That could be tools that explain medical bills and insurance decisions in plain language. It could be tools that help families find assistance programs they qualify for but have never heard of. It could be tools that walk tenants and homeowners through their rights before a problem turns into a crisis. The technology for this already exists. What's usually missing is someone who has been on the other side of the kitchen table and cares about getting it right for the people who need it most.

Your firm's work stood out to me for that reason. You represent individuals and small businesses against HOAs and insurance companies, organizations that have far more resources and far more knowledge of the rules. That gap in knowledge and power is exactly what I want to work on, just with code instead of courtrooms. A good lawyer makes sure someone isn't steamrolled because they didn't know their rights. I want to build tools that make sure people know those rights before they ever need a lawyer.

In the short term, my focus is finishing my degree strong. My final semesters are the most demanding part of the program, and the same pressures I've dealt with for years haven't disappeared just because I'm close to the finish line. This scholarship would give me room to focus on my coursework instead of worrying about how to cover it.

In the long term, I want to work in software that has a direct effect on people's everyday lives, not just their entertainment. I want to bring the perspective of someone who has had to work through these systems without help. I also want to be someone others can come to, whether it's family, friends, or students coming up behind me, when they're trying to figure out the same things I once had to figure out alone.

Trailblazing, to me, doesn't mean being the first person to do something impressive. It means clearing a path so the next person has an easier time getting through. That's the kind of impact I want to have, and it's the reason I'm working as hard as I am to finish what I started.